This search for wider acceptability even led Modi to reach out to Muslims. Our election surveys were consistently showing that Muslims still remained very wary of the BJP prime ministerial candidate. Zafar Sareshwala, Modi's gnome-like, media-friendly Muslim face from Gujarat, was assigned the task. Zafar has a strong bond with Hindi film writer Salim Khan and his actor son Salman. Salim had been in touch with Modi since 2009 and the two had struck a friendship. Salman, Hindi cinema's box office king, was more wary. 'I am not politically inclined at all,' the actor had once told me. We had double-dated together once in college; while I had grown old and grey, the six-pack star remained the eternal eighteen-year-old.

It was Salim who persuaded Salman to make the trip to Ahmedabad. Salman's film *Jai Ho* was releasing on 24 January and the actor was on a punishing promotional campaign. Modi suggested 14 January, the date of Gujarat's famous Uttarayan kite-flying festival, for a meeting. The moment he arrived in Gujarat, Salman was treated like an honoured state guest. The astute political salesman, ever alert for a headline-grabbing opportunity, Modi took Salman on a kite-flying outing. Salman in a Being Human T-shirt flying a kite next to Modi—it was the ideal photo op the BJP leader craved for, even if Salman stopped short of endorsing him as prime minister. 'To have a popular icon like Salman standing next to Modi helped us a lot when we were trying to convince Muslims to give Modi a chance,' claims Sareshwala. The kite-flying happened in a Hindu-dominated area of Ghatlodia (no Muslim comes here, claimed Zafar). The photo op was now being projected as a momentary breaking of the infamous invisible 'borders' that divide many of Gujarat's towns between Hindu and Muslim quarters.

In February, Sareshwala organized a trade exhibition to showcase Muslim-owned businesses in Gujarat where Modi was the star attraction. 'You must come and see what Modi is doing for the Muslims. You can even sit next to him on stage as a special invitee,' he told me. I attended the function but preferred not to be on stage. In his brief speech, Modi spoke glowingly of Gujarat's Kutch Muslim artisans and the community's work